

Death Matches

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RETURN TO CASTLE WOLFENSTEIN

It's good to be back

It's been nearly 10 years since Allied espionage soldier William J. 'B.J.' Blazkowicz made his first escape from Castle Wolfenstein. After almost a decade comes the long awaited sequel to the game that started it all. With a huge budget and a modified *Quake III* engine behind

are highly detailed, their movements realistic.

RTCW is a mix of elements from the great shooters of the last decade, blending stealth with action, *Half-Life* at some parts and at some places, *Thief*. The game's seven missions are divided across 26 levels and take you through a variety of locations, each differing in structure and design. Some

weak enemy AI which fails to respond even to gunfire at some places. The stealth feels more like a 'me too' feature than a gameplay device.

Single player mode in the game is quite short, with about 13 hours of gameplay at most. While this version may

not have lived up to the hype, the multiplayer mode adds extra grace and makes it a winner.

Developer: Gray Matter Studios

Genre: Action

Web site: www.returntowolfenstein.com

Rating: ★★★★★



the project, fans of the FPS genre have keenly awaited *Return to Castle Wolfenstein* (RTCW).

RTCW's story unfolds in the early levels through seemingly unrelated events. B.J. Blazkowicz is asked to infiltrate and examine the activities of the Nazi Paranormal Division, headquartered at Castle Wolfenstein. The story progresses through a wide variety of mediums-in-engine cut scenes, enemy conversations, mission briefings and scattered notes around the levels.

The graphics engine is truly next-generation, and together with the level design makes for some of the smoothest gameplay on single player mode. Enemy models

of the missions exercise stealth while others are run-and-gun missions. The ones that are centred on combat with Nazi troops are highly engrossing. The guns are modelled marvellously—especially the flamethrower and the sniper—and give off very impressive sound feedback. Gaming sweetness lies in seeing the flamethrower creating a near arc in the air.

The pitfalls? With highly objective-oriented missions, linear gameplay renders the objectives near redundant to the game's levels. The action parts of the game were really incredible; the stealth parts were not, partly due to the

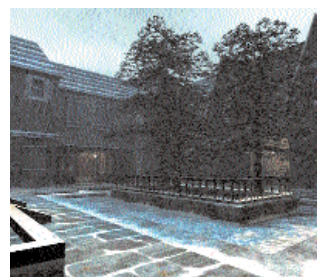
LOCK AND LOAD

Pick and Play

Budget game packs come in three flavours: games that have been out for a decade or more; shareware compilations; and custom-built nonentities. However, there are glimmers of hope. Companies such as Milestone and EA have made noble efforts at improving the overall quality of budget titles with games that play smoothly on your not-so-state-of-the-art-PC-any-more type of set up. *Lock and Load*, the first FPS-only game pack, is not a run-of-the-mill budget title but is a good chance for the FPS enthusiast to play games that were overshadowed by *Half-Life*.

This is what the line up looks like: *Soldier of Fortune* Platinum Edition, *SiN*, *Kingpin: Life of Crime*, *Spec Ops II* with *Spec Ops II: Operation Bravo* an expansion pack.

Soldier of Fortune is an ultraviolent shooter. It uses the proprietary GHOU technology that manages individual hit points and makes gore even more visceral. *Kingpin* puts you on the streets as a gangster, where violence is the



only means of negotiation. With in-game music from rap group Cypress Hill, this game has one of the best sound effects for any FPS. *SiN*, an

under-appreciated classic from Ritual, will surprise you in many ways, with controllable vehicles and fantastic level design. *Spec Ops II* is a Tactical sim where you assume the role of squad commander. However, the game is riddled with bugs that sour the experience.

Released during 1998-99, these games have an excellent mod community, you can download custom missions